

## Chapter 81-1

Liang Shi remembered that previously at the entrance of the concert hall, when Zhao Ling was dumped by his girlfriend, his girlfriend had said she had fallen for Shen Siyan.

Anyone hearing this name would think it was a girl.

But... it was a guy?

Liang Shi and Zhao Xuning's astonishment was noticed by Zhao Ling, and he was also confused. "So you didn't know before?"

Zhao Xuning shook her head, her gaze still fixed on that direction. "No."

Shen Hui and Shen Siyan had already walked far away. She could only watch their retreating figures from afar.

Liang Shi also looked over. The siblings both had figures like clothes hangers.<sup>1</sup> The older sister was considered tall among Omegas, and the younger brother was a head taller than his sister, with good fashion sense too.

Standing together, the handsome man and beautiful woman made for quite an eye-catching sight.

Liang Shi patted Zhao Xuning's shoulder to offer comfort.

But Zhao Xuning turned around, her gaze icy cold, like shards of ice in the depths of winter. "Remove it."

Liang Shi: "?"

How ungrateful.

She withdrew her hand and stuffed it into her coat pocket, continuing to chat with Zhao Ling. "Which characters are used for the 'Si' and 'Yan' in his name? Is it the 'Yan' as in rock?"

Zhao Ling was still looking down at the photos from earlier, quite satisfied. He answered Liang Shi with a smile: "No, it's the 'Yan' with the female radical."<sup>2</sup>

"That name is so delicate." Liang Shi said, "Quite unique."

"It's not strange on him." Zhao Ling had a very poor relationship with him. After entering university, almost every girl he liked had run off to like Shen Siyan instead.

Good at studying, high looks, skilled at horseback riding, and also good at gaming.

Most importantly: a lone wolf.

This trait attracted many Omegas and Betas. Any pretty one would want to try their luck with him, but basically all of them returned in defeat.

Legends about him still circulated in the grade group chat.

Right after enrollment, he made a pretty senior girl—famous for "slaying Alphas"—fail miserably, losing fifty thousand yuan.

Because their bet was fifty thousand yuan.

After this incident came to light, someone who had drunk too much teased Shen Siyan about it at a party, asking what his thoughts were.

Shen Siyan had just two words: "Boring."

Everyone thought he was the most boring one, but Omegas just loved his type.

The grudge between Zhao Ling and him was absolutely irreconcilable.

After hearing this, Liang Shi's eyelid twitched. She thought to herself, how big of a grudge could a bunch of kids have? But then Zhao Ling said expressionlessly: "The grudge of stealing my wife."

Liang Shi: "..."

She suddenly remembered what happened that day at the concert hall entrance.

That was truly an undeserved disaster for Shen Siyan.

Zhao Ling invited them to eat outside the school.

Because Zhao Xuning didn't really like the atmosphere of group meals, Zhao Ling had the junior students go find their own place to eat, leaving just the three of them.

On the way to eat, Zhao Ling started chatting. "Shen Siyan is really strange. He's a total sister-complex, plus a tattletale, and everything he does is so effeminate. It's hard to believe he's an Alpha."

Zhao Xuning glanced at him sideways. "And that's a reason for you to hit someone?"

"Didn't he end up hitting me in the end?" Zhao Ling showed her his wrist. "There's still a wound here."

Zhao Xuning: "The one who provokes first..."

"Ning-jie!"<sup>3</sup> Zhao Ling was so anxious his eyes went wide. "What are you saying? Who's actually your younger cousin here?"

"I side with reason, not with family." Zhao Xuning said.

Zhao Ling: "..."

He gritted his teeth in anger. "I think you're just siding with that older sister, what's her name... Shen Hui, right?"

Zhao Xuning: "None of your business."

Zhao Ling was so angry at Zhao Xuning that he was about to explode. Liang Shi remarked from the side, "Has she been bullying you like this since you were kids?"

Zhao Ling immediately looked aggrieved and found someone to complain to. "Yeah! Sister Liang, let me tell you, my cousin is just a..."

"Smack."

Zhao Xuning slapped Zhao Ling on the shoulder. "Will you die if you don't talk?"

Zhao Ling: "..."

"You see that, right?" Zhao Ling immediately distanced himself far from Zhao Xuning. "She's a violent maniac."

"This is called fighting violence with violence." Zhao Xuning said.

Zhao Ling made a face at her.

The atmosphere between the two was actually quite affectionate. For Liang Shi, who had never experienced sibling bonds, it was quite novel.

Although after coming to this world, Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe had let her experience a little of it.

But both of them were older and had their own families. The care they showed her was mainly in terms of living necessities and finances. She had always been reserved and wouldn't have this kind of relaxed chatting atmosphere with them.

This kind of interaction was a bit like children.

Playfully fighting, but never holding grudges. Even if they argued, they would make up soon after.

It was quite enviable.

"Have you two been like this since you were kids?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Ling nodded. "Yes, I've been their punching bag—hers and my older sister's."

Liang Shi chuckled softly. "Poor you."

Zhao Ling nodded repeatedly. "Both my older sisters are fierce and heartless."

"I'll call your older sister." Zhao Xuning said.

Zhao Ling immediately backed down. "Don't, Ning-jie, I was wrong."

Zhao Xuning glanced at him sideways but said nothing.

Zhao Ling followed beside Liang Shi, looking like a fawning lackey, and couldn't help but sigh. "In comparison, Sister Liang, you're a fairy—the kind that doesn't belong to the mortal world."<sup>4</sup>

Liang Shi was amused by him and teased, "Even if you flatter me like this, I'm still not paying the bill later."

"I'll pay." Zhao Ling said, "You've helped me so much. How could I possibly let you pay?"

Zhao Ling complained to her about Shen Siyan, that nitpicky cold weirdo, and also mentioned his name.

"He seems to have three older sisters." Zhao Ling said, "But the third sister died shortly after birth."

"So he inherited his sister's name?" Liang Shi was surprised.

"No." Zhao Ling said, "Think about it—'Siyan,' it means 'missing Yan,' his third sister, right? That's why I said he's definitely a sister-complex."

Zhao Xuning said coldly from the side: "Still better than you being unfilial."

Zhao Ling: "...???"

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1. "Clothes hangers" (衣服架子) — A Chinese expression meaning someone with a figure that makes any clothes look good on them, like a mannequin or clothes hanger. ↩
  2. The character "妍" (yán) — meaning beautiful or elegant, contains the female/woman radical (女). This character is typically used in feminine names, which is why it's surprising for a male to have it in his name. ↩
  3. "Ning-jie" — "Jie" (姐) means "older sister." Zhao Ling is calling Zhao Xuning by a shortened, affectionate version of her name plus the honorific for older sister, showing their familial relationship. ↩
  4. "Doesn't belong to the mortal world" (不食人間煙火) — Literally "doesn't eat the smoke and fire of the mortal world," a Chinese idiom describing someone who seems ethereal, otherworldly, or too pure and elegant to be part of ordinary human life. ↩

## Chapter 81-2

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Zhao Ling's life consisted of being bullied by Zhao Xuning and Zhao Ying on a daily basis, as well as constantly teetering on the edge of being infuriated to death by his two older sisters.

He had already gotten used to Zhao Xuning's sharp tongue, but regarding Zhao Xuning's tendency to side with outsiders over family,<sup>1</sup> he still held an opposing opinion.

Mainly because he felt that Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui were unlikely to work out.

"Sis." Zhao Ling thought it over again and again but still couldn't help saying, "Before, I thought she wasn't good enough for you, but now it's obvious—we're not good enough for her."

They happened to reach the restaurant entrance. As Zhao Ling pushed the door open ahead of them, he said, "I advise you to give up on this. How can a broken mirror possibly be glued back together?"

"Watch out—" Several voices rang out simultaneously, startling Zhao Ling.

He turned around and found Shen Siyan holding a food tray with a dark expression. The soup and rice in the tray had spilled, and some had splashed onto him.

Zhao Ling: "..."

Well, what a coincidence.

Liang Shi witnessed the whole thing from behind.

When Zhao Ling was opening the door, he was talking to Zhao Xuning, so he was a bit reckless. Shen Siyan had been carrying his tray just fine, but because of the unexpected turn, he almost collided with Zhao Ling. Afraid of accidentally hurting Zhao Ling, he moved the tray toward himself, which ended up getting food on his own clothes.

"Watch where you're going." Zhao Ling struck first. "There are people coming and going here. What if you bumped into someone?"

Shen Siyan was speechless, his brows furrowed tightly. "You're the one who wasn't watching where you were walking."

He had very handsome features that didn't match his name at all. His voice was also particularly cold. Especially his eye color—a light brown that looked like he was wearing colored contacts, giving his handsome face a somewhat bewitching quality.

Liang Shi glanced inside and immediately spotted Shen Hui sitting there.

Shen Hui had originally been looking down at her phone, but after hearing the commotion, she raised her head and watched silently.

Liang Shi's gaze happened to meet Shen Hui's in mid-air. She smiled and nodded, showing a friendly attitude first.

But Shen Hui had no reaction, her expression indifferent.

Only then did Liang Shi notice her eyes—very similar to Shen Siyan's, both with light brown pupils. Quite rare.

This eye color on Shen Hui's face made her appear particularly aloof and unfeeling.

Even though the midday sunlight was refracting down, illuminating her skin until it glowed, it still made her seem unapproachable.

Yet as Liang Shi looked, she inexplicably felt that their eye shape was very familiar, but she couldn't recall where else she had seen the same eyes.

Meanwhile, Shen Siyan and Zhao Ling were already at each other's throats. Both were young men in the prime of youth, each more hot-blooded than the other.

After just two sentences of disagreement, they were glaring at each other angrily.

It was Zhao Xuning who spoke up: "Zhao Ling, apologize."

Zhao Ling was surprised, his questioning tone carrying grievance: "Ning-jie?"

The single character "Ning" was dragged out with all sorts of inflections.

"Apologize." Zhao Xuning's tone was very serious, her voice cold—it was a command.

But Zhao Ling got angry. He retorted: "I won't. I didn't do anything wrong."

They were blocking the doorway. Customers behind them couldn't get in, while customers inside watched the show.

Shen Siyan glanced at him, frowning. After a moment, he said: "Forget it."

He carried his spilled soup and rice away. After sitting back down, Shen Hui handed him napkins to wipe the oil stains on his clothes.

This was a self-service restaurant with three food pickup stations. The one Shen Siyan had used was the least crowded, but because it was easy to get caught by the door, most people didn't use it.

It was nearly lunchtime, and people kept streaming in.

Because of the earlier unpleasantness, Zhao Ling talked less, but since Liang Shi was still there, he maintained basic courtesy. He went to the counter to order, got a ticket number, then came back to ask Liang Shi what she wanted to drink.

Liang Shi asked for plain water. Zhao Ling was secretly sulking at Zhao Xuning and didn't ask what she wanted, directly getting her an iced cola and shoving it over.

Zhao Xuning crossed her arms and looked at him. "Why didn't you apologize just now?"

Zhao Ling had just opened the pull-tab on the can, his finger still inside. Hearing this, he frowned: "Why should I apologize?"

"You weren't watching where you were going and bumped into him." Zhao Xuning said, "Why didn't you apologize?"

Zhao Ling: "Couldn't you have said it nicely?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

A few seconds later, Zhao Xuning's tone softened. "Sorry."

Zhao Ling: "..."

He hadn't expected to get an apology from Zhao Xuning so easily. Zhao Ling was stunned for a moment, then his tone became a little happy. "It's fine, I forgive you."

Liang Shi watched from the side, deeply moved.

So this was what family was like?

One second they were at each other's throats in confrontation, the next second they were all smiles.

Then Zhao Ling came to verify with her, asking about what had happened earlier. Liang Shi told him truthfully.

Zhao Ling sat there thinking for a moment, then got up to find Shen Siyan.

Liang Shi sat there, holding a cup of hot water to warm her hands, steam rising before her eyes.

She watched as Zhao Ling walked righteously over to Shen Siyan's table, placed two drinks on their table, cleared his throat and called out to Shen Siyan, saying in a low voice: "I'm sorry, I was wrong earlier."

Liang Shi was shocked.

She had thought that boys this age might get into a fight, but would never apologize.

Zhao Ling had overturned her perception.

Shen Siyan's response also made her eyes light up: "It's fine now. My attitude wasn't good earlier either. Let's just let this pass."

Liang Shi: "..."

She looked at Zhao Xuning and couldn't help but exclaim: "Their families raised them so well."

Zhao Xuning raised an eyebrow, as if to say—isn't that how it should be?

After Zhao Ling returned, the atmosphere was the same as usual, continuing to chatter away. Liang Shi just listened to the lively conversation from the side.

However, while eating, Liang Shi was chatting casually with Zhao Ling when she suddenly said: "The Shen siblings' eye color is so beautiful. It looks very familiar."

Zhao Ling: "?"

He gulped down his soup and rice and looked at Liang Shi in astonishment.

Liang Shi asked: "What's wrong?"

Zhao Ling blinked and answered: "It does look familiar. Why don't you just go look in a mirror?"

Liang Shi: "...?"

What the heck?

Hearing this, Zhao Xuning also looked over. She carefully examined Liang Shi's eyes and said objectively: "They are quite similar."

Zhao Ling nodded: "I was just about to say—the eyes of you three are very similar. Mainly the pupil color. It's like you're all wearing colored contacts."

Speaking of this, Zhao Ling also told an amusing story.

When they went to take ID photos for their student cards at the start of the semester, when it was Shen Siyan's turn, the photographer told him to remove his colored contacts. Shen Siyan said he wasn't wearing any.

The photographer insisted he was and even thought he was being dishonest, getting so angry he wanted to quit.

After an examination, they discovered that Shen Siyan's natural eye color was just like that. It turned out to be a big misunderstanding, and the photographer was extremely embarrassed.

Liang Shi nodded: "That kind of trouble does happen."

Back in her original world, when she went to take her ID photo, it had been the same.

Shen Hui and Shen Siyan had arrived first and left together after finishing their meal.

Zhao Xuning kept staring at their retreating figures until they disappeared from sight.

Liang Shi and Zhao Ling exchanged glances simultaneously and shook their heads helplessly.

When it comes to matters of the heart, only those who experience it truly understand.

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1. "Side with outsiders over family" (胳膊肘往外拐) — Literally "the elbow bends outward," a Chinese idiom meaning to favor outsiders over one's own family members, implying disloyalty or putting strangers' interests above family. ⇐



## Chapter 81-3

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The photoshoot with Zhao Ling went quite smoothly. Zhao Ling added her on WeChat through Zhao Xuning and also gave her an envelope—her payment.

Zhao Ling said: "It's not that I won't transfer money to you. I just prefer using cash. It gives the illusion of having a lot of money."

Liang Shi didn't mind and thanked him.

But Zhao Ling waved his hands in a fluster. "You're clearly the one who helped me out big time. I'll send you the original photos later. Also, this is for a class assignment and might be entered into a competition, so I wanted to let you know in advance."

Liang Shi nodded: "That's fine."

After leaving Qingyi University, Zhao Xuning accompanied her to the mall since it was on the way.

Liang Shi bought everything on her shopping list one by one and arranged for the furniture and appliances to be delivered to the designated location.

The delivery time was set for 7 PM.

That happened to be close to when the other party got off work. If she wasn't there at that time, Xu Qingzhu would be.

She also left both her and Xu Qingzhu's phone numbers with the mall.

The money she spent on shopping happened to be the payment Zhao Ling gave her—two thousand yuan.

For the amount that wasn't enough, she swiped her card.

Originally, Zhao Xuning wanted to pay, saying it was her apartment and she should be the one to furnish it, but Liang Shi stopped her.

Zhao Xuning didn't have the habit of fighting with others over the bill, so she let her be.

By the time they finished shopping at the mall, it was almost time for Liang Shi to go to work. She hurried to the company and happened to run into Liang Xinhe when she arrived.

Liang Xinhe looked haggard, holding a cup of coffee. His assistant followed behind him reporting on matters, while he was so tired he was yawning. When he saw Liang Shi, he asked: "Why are you coming from that direction?"

"Huh?" Liang Shi said, "I went to the mall."

The two stood side by side in the elevator. Seeing that his condition was really quite poor, Liang Shi asked with concern: "Are you sick?"

"Not me." Liang Xinhe said, "Our mom is sick."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, momentarily speechless, not even wanting to ask what illness it was.

"At least ask about it." Liang Xinhe had a tone of disappointment, like he was frustrated she wasn't living up to expectations.<sup>1</sup> "How can you not ask a single question?"

Liang Shi told him honestly: "I don't really want to know."

"How did our mom offend you?" Liang Xinhe said, "It was just one argument, wasn't it? How can there be overnight grudges between mother and daughter? How many nights has it been for you two now?"

Liang Xinhe was still lecturing her when, in the blink of an eye, she reached her floor. Just as she was about to get off the elevator and escape, Liang Xinhe changed the floor. "Come sit in my office for a bit."

Liang Shi: "..."

There was no escaping.

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1. "Frustrated she wasn't living up to expectations" (恨鐵不成鋼) — A Chinese idiom literally meaning "hating iron for not becoming steel," expressing disappointment that someone isn't living up to their potential or isn't doing what they should be doing. ⇐

## Chapter 81-4

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After Liang Xinhe entered the office, he gulped down the rest of his coffee in a few mouthfuls, then elegantly tossed the paper cup away and sank his exhausted body into the soft sofa chair.

Liang Shi closed the door and glanced at the time. "Hurry up and tell me. I still need to go downstairs to clock in."

Liang Xinhe: "..."

"I've never seen you this diligent normally." Liang Xinhe said with slight dissatisfaction. "You're resigning anyway. What does it matter if you clock in or not?"

"It's different." Liang Shi said, "As long as you're a monk for a day, you ring the bell for a day."<sup>1</sup>

Liang Xinhe: "..."

He rubbed his forehead helplessly. After a while, he tentatively asked: "Why don't you try to persuade Big Brother?"

Liang Shi was completely confused, having no idea what had happened. "What do I need to persuade Big Brother about?"

"Last night." Liang Xinhe propped his arms on the desk, cleared his throat, and began speaking with the posture of someone about to tell Liang Shi a story. "Our mom and Big Brother got into an argument because of you."

Liang Shi: "..."

She wasn't even there. What was there to argue about?

Liang Xinhe suddenly asked: "Has Big Brother contacted you?"

Liang Shi shook her head: "Not yet. Why?"

"Big Brother has disappeared." Liang Xinhe said, "We've been calling him, but he won't answer. He didn't come to work today either."

Liang Shi: "..."

Was he really that willful?

Liang Shi suddenly felt that something big had happened at the Liang family last night.

Her rationality told her that she actually didn't need to know.

But curiosity drove her to ask: "Why? What was there to argue about? I wasn't even there."

As she spoke, she took out her phone and called Liang Xinzhou. Just as Liang Xinhe was about to explain last night's "bloodbath," Liang Xinzhou's call went through.

Liang Xinhe: "?"

Liang Xinzhou's voice carried exhaustion, and his tone was cold, though one could tell he was deliberately suppressing his emotions. "Liang Shi?"

"It's me." Liang Shi said gently, "Big Brother, where are you?"

Liang Xinzhou paused on his end without answering. Instead, he asked her: "Where have you moved to now?"

Liang Shi said: "I'm renting a friend's apartment outside. What's wrong?"

"I have another property here." Liang Xinzhou said, "It's in Chenjiang Residential Complex. When you have time, go take a look, and then I'll transfer it to your name."

"No need." Liang Shi immediately refused. "You don't need to give me an apartment. I'll buy one myself when the time comes."

At the same time, Liang Shi noticed that rich people probably all liked buying apartments along the river.

And they even bought in the same residential complex.

The complex Liang Xinzhou mentioned was exactly where Liang Shi had just moved into.

...

It could only be said to be quite a coincidence.

"That place was originally an investment property of mine." Liang Xinzhou said, "Cancel the apartment you're renting and go live there. It's also quite close to Minghui Jewelry."

"I'm already living there now." Liang Shi said helplessly, having no choice but to come clean. "It's an apartment a friend temporarily lent me. I'm also looking to buy now. You don't need to worry about me. Really, I'm fine."

Liang Xinzhou fell silent again on his end, while Liang Xinhe mouthed to her, telling her to ask Liang Xinzhou where he was now.

Only then did Liang Shi speak up: "Big Brother, where are you right now? Everyone's going crazy looking for you."

"You don't need to worry about it." Liang Xinzhou still didn't tell her. "I want some time alone."

"What about Sister-in-law?" Liang Shi asked, "Does Sister-in-law know?"

"She's with me." Liang Xinzhou said, "I'll send you the specific information about that apartment later. The property management has the keys. It's just that no one has lived there for a long time, so you'll need to have someone clean it after you go in. This apartment will be yours from now on."

Liang Shi: "..."

Do all you rich people like giving away apartments this much?

Liang Shi wanted to ask more, but Liang Xinzhou didn't want to chat with her anymore. He just told her not to worry about these things and to focus on filming.

Then he hung up.

When she called back, Liang Xinzhou's phone was already turned off.

Liang Shi and Liang Xinhe looked at each other in dismay. Finally, Liang Shi asked: "So it was because of the villa matter?"

Liang Xinhe shook his head and sighed helplessly: "Not just that."

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1. "As long as you're a monk for a day, you ring the bell for a day" (當一天和尚撞一天鐘) — A Chinese proverb meaning that as long as you hold a position, you should fulfill your duties. It emphasizes doing one's job properly regardless of circumstances. ↩

## Chapter 81-5

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Last night at the Liang family was indeed a "bloodbath."

Qiu Zimin and Father Liang had brought back their long-lost daughter—Guo Xinran.

Before this daughter arrived, everyone had already obtained her information and knew she had lived in poverty. And Liang Xinzhou had finally, under Liang Xinhe's persuasion, decided to wait and see how things developed, and hadn't moved out.

That evening when Guo Xinran came back, they even held a welcome ceremony for her.

Her appearance was similar to Liang Wanwan's. Even though they had never spent time together growing up, there was still that bit of blood connection.

Qiu Zimin also showed a rare smile in recent days. On the surface, the family appeared harmonious, which was passable enough.

Except that Liang Xinzhou's expression wasn't very friendly—but he was always like that, often wearing a stern face. Even Ling Dang would usually complain, "Why does Big Uncle always like to keep a straight face and frown?"

She would even occasionally imitate Liang Xinzhou's serious expression.

Everyone was used to it.

But the newly arrived younger sister, after dinner, quietly asked Qiu Zimin in a timid, trembling voice, "Does Big Brother not like me? Did I do something to make Big Brother angry?"

She had asked Qiu Zimin quietly, but Ling Dang happened to overhear.

Ling Dang said from the side: "No, New Auntie, my Big Uncle has always been like that."

Guo Xinran blinked, looking like she was about to cry. "But he's so gentle with Ling Dang. Only with me... I feel like I did something wrong and made Big Brother unhappy."

Upon hearing this, Qiu Zimin's face immediately darkened. She went to confront Liang Xinzhou and lectured him: "Can't you just smile? Your sister being able to come back is a huge blessing. Why are you still wearing that expression like you bear some deep grudge?"

Yu Wan, who was sitting nearby chatting with Sun Meirou, heard this and couldn't help but defend Liang Xinzhou. "Mom, Xinzhou has always been like this. It's not like he looks like he bears some deep grudge."

"How is it not?" Qiu Zimin glanced at her. "Why are you defending him? I'm talking to him, not to you."

These words were rather infuriating, which prompted Liang Xinzhou to immediately respond: "My wife can't defend me?"

He was simply speaking up for Yu Wan, but unexpectedly, Qiu Zimin got angry the moment she heard it. "Right, right, right, you two husband and wife are so good together. Your wife just defends you, and everything I do is wrong, is that it?"

"I didn't say that." Liang Xinzhou said, "There's no need to over-interpret."

"I'm over-interpreting? Liang Xinzhou, what are you saying? Are you also trying to say I'm wrongly accusing you? Anyone can see that your cold face today is deliberately shown to us." At this point, Qiu Zimin started settling old and new scores together. "Do you think I don't know what you're thinking? You think if you drive Xinran away, Liang Shi will come back? Let me tell you—impossible!"

Liang Xinzhou's brow furrowed tightly. "I didn't say that."

Yu Wan, sitting to the side, couldn't stay seated anymore and said coldly: "Mom, how can you say that? Xinzhou has never targeted anyone."

"Shut up! I'm talking to Liang Xinzhou." Qiu Zimin said harshly, "You don't have a say in this."

Yu Wan was furious. "But you can't wrongly accuse him like this either! He works so hard every day. You all don't go to the company, and even Dad can leave Haizhou for three days. If you want to bring your daughter back, then bring her back. Everyone has welcomed her. Why must everyone smile? Liang Xinzhou didn't even smile much when we took our wedding photos!"

Yu Wan was different from Sun Meirou.

Sun Meirou had a gentle personality. When speaking with Qiu Zimin normally, she was always deferential and respectful, afraid of displeasing her.

But Yu Wan's family was also quite powerful, and she was the only daughter. She had always been busy working at her own family's company, so her personality was much more assertive. Usually, because she didn't spend much time at home, she wouldn't clash with Qiu Zimin.

But now, in front of the whole family, with Qiu Zimin speaking to Liang Xinzhou like this, Yu Wan couldn't stand it.

The two started arguing, and Sun Meirou even tugged at Yu Wan's hem, signaling her to say less.

Qiu Zimin was also stunned by what Yu Wan said, but as the mother-in-law, in front of so many people, she naturally couldn't lose face.

So Qiu Zimin said harshly: "Shut up! I'm talking to Liang Xinzhou. You don't have a say in this."

"Mom." Liang Xinzhou stood up and blocked Yu Wan behind him. "What do you mean by that?"

"What do you mean?" Qiu Zimin glared at him. "Do you have to break with the family just for a Liang Shi? We're the ones who share blood ties with you."

"No." Liang Xinzhou looked at her and said calmly, "This has nothing to do with Liang Shi right now. She's not even in this house. I'm only asking you—what did you mean just now?"

Qiu Zimin was taken aback. "Are you questioning me?"

"Simply asking." Liang Xinzhou adopted his business negotiation stance. "Why doesn't Yu Wan have a say? Is it wrong for her to speak up for me? Why are you being fierce with her?"

"She was being nosy." Qiu Zimin said coldly, "And you—why do you keep wearing that cold face? Everyone's happy, only you..."

"Yu Wan just said it." Liang Xinzhou scoffed lightly. "I didn't even smile when I took wedding photos with her. I've lived for over thirty years, and I barely smiled at my own wedding. Why should I smile just because she's back? Am I someone who sells smiles?"<sup>1</sup>

The conversation was veering further off track, with cold, biting questions.

Liang Xinhe had Sun Meirou take Ling Dang back to her room, away from this smokeless battlefield. But as Ling Dang went upstairs, she pouted: "New Auntie thought Big Uncle's cold face meant he disliked her, but I already explained it."

Ling Dang even gave a cold snort. "Big Uncle has always been like that. I never said he disliked me. Hmph."

Sun Meirou immediately covered Ling Dang's mouth and carried her upstairs.

Ling Dang's words made everyone shift their attention to Guo Xinran. But Guo Xinran looked at Qiu Zimin with teary eyes: "Mom, that's not what I meant."

Seeing her like this, Qiu Zimin's heart immediately ached terribly. She quickly said: "Mom knows. Don't cry."

Then Qiu Zimin told Liang Xinzhou and his wife to apologize to Guo Xinran.

The more Liang Xinzhou listened, the more outrageous he found it. He said coldly: "Do you really think I'm someone who sells smiles?"

Qiu Zimin was furious, but she redirected the conflict toward Yu Wan. "It's your wife who corrupted you. What's this about selling smiles? We're all family, getting along harmoniously—why use such an embarrassing term?"

"What does this have to do with Yu Wan?" Liang Xinzhou firmly protected Yu Wan. "Why don't you say that you've gone too far? She comes back, I throw her a welcome banquet—do I also have to coddle her? Is that really necessary?"

At that moment, Qiu Zimin's phone rang. She answered it, and her finger accidentally touched the speakerphone button, so the voice on the phone reached everyone's ears.



The housekeeper said: "Madam, the villa at Shallow Water Bay has been sold for thirteen million yuan. Please check if the money has arrived in the account. The Third Young Miss has already been informed. She'll be there on Sunday..."

Qiu Zimin suddenly panicked and hurriedly hung up.

But everyone had already heard what they needed to hear.

Shallow Water Bay?

Wasn't that where Liang Shi lived?

Liang Xinzhou was shocked. He questioned coldly: "You sold the wedding house that was given to Liang Shi?"

Qiu Zimin had been feeling a bit guilty, but hearing him ask like this, she immediately said unhappily: "Can't I sell my own things? It's just one house. If she's capable, she can go buy one herself."

"You..." Liang Xinzhou was so angry he was at a loss for words. "You... what are you saying?"

Qiu Zimin became more confident. "I'm telling her to buy her own place. Didn't she feel that staying in the Liang family wronged her? Didn't she think I haven't treated her well all these years? Then I might as well live up to my bad reputation! I put so much effort into treating her well, indulging her, and all I got in return was being blamed. Then let her go on her own. After all, she doesn't want to be in the Liang family anymore anyway."

"You raised her to be that way, and now you want her to go fend for herself?" Liang Xinzhou laughed in anger. "What are you thinking? Mom, have you lost your mind..."<sup>2</sup>

"Slap—"

Before he could finish, Qiu Zimin slapped him across the face. Her eyes were already red with fury. "Liang Xinzhou, what did you just say about me?!"

Liang Xinzhou's glasses were knocked off, landing at Yu Wan's feet.

Yu Wan was stunned. She opened her mouth but didn't know what to say, and could only hold Liang Xinzhou's hand tightly.

A moment later, Yu Wan was so angry her voice was trembling. She accused angrily: "Look at yourself right now—you're the one who's lost your mind!"

Qiu Zimin was so angry she raised her hand to hit Yu Wan, but Liang Xinzhou caught her arm.

Liang Xinzhou glared at her fiercely and said coldly: "Enough!"

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1. "Someone who sells smiles" (賣笑的) — This phrase literally refers to someone who smiles for money, traditionally used to describe entertainers or courtesans. Liang Xinzhou uses it sarcastically to ask if he's expected to smile on command like a performer. ⇐
2. "Lost your mind" (鬼迷心竅) — A Chinese idiom literally meaning "possessed by ghosts" or "bewitched," used to describe someone who has become confused or made irrational decisions, as if their mind has been clouded by supernatural forces. ⇐